

Measuring acidity

Acidity is measured in pH, which stands for “power of hydrogen.” Neutral substances such as water have a pH of 7. A substance with a pH lower than this is acidic; one with a pH higher than this (up to 14) is alkaline. The pH measures the concentration of hydrogen ions. Each whole pH number on the scale is ten times more acidic or basic than the previous number. For example, a substance with a pH of 6 has ten times more hydrogen ions in it than water, which has a pH of 7.

► Indicators

Chemicals used to test whether a substance is acid or alkaline are called indicators. Litmus was the first indicator used to show pH. It produces a red color for acid and blue for alkali. However its range of colors is limited, making it hard to judge the precise pH. A dye called universal indicator is more practical and produces a wide range of colors indicating where the solution fits into the pH scale.

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Indigestion tablets

The discomfort of indigestion is caused by digestive acids leaking out of the stomach into the esophagus. This causes a burning sensation as it attacks the soft lining of the throat. Antacid tablets contain alkalis—often magnesium hydroxide—that neutralize these acids into harmless salts.



Rainwater is slightly acidic because carbon dioxide dissolves in it, making carbonic acid.

